



Applying CSS to HTML 30m

CSS styling can be applied to a single instance of an HTML element, a type of HTML element, such as `<p>`, or a set of HTML elements named using an attribute. But how is it done?

You can apply CSS to HTML by using:

- an external style sheet
- an internal style sheet
- inline styles.



You learned about HTML styling, focusing on inline styles, earlier. If you need a refresher, we recommend taking a look at the following pages:

[HTML block and inline elements](#) →

Let's look at each of the CSS methods below.

Method	Styles are defined by	Usage
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External style sheet	CSS code in a .css file. Browsers are directed to the styles via the <link> element inside a web page's <head> element.	An external style sheet is the preferred method of applying CSS because: - it allows you to edit all linked instances of the style at once - the CSS code is kept consistent in a single, easy-to-find location - you can reference multiple style sheets, allowing the look and feel to be defined in a modular manner.
Internal style sheet	CSS code inside the <head> element of a web page.	Styles are limited to each page. You would have to repeat the head tag across the site for the look and feel to remain consistent. This has a greater chance of error and is time-consuming if changes are needed.
Inline styles	adding CSS code to an HTML tag such as <body> or <h1> in the line of code using the <style> attribute.	Inline styles are a very time-consuming method of applying styles for the development and maintenance of a website because: - they are limited to a line or page section of HTML. You are styling each part of the page as you code it. - the style information is then scattered throughout the HTML page code. You would need to read and change it all to update or fix it!

Advantages and disadvantages

The following table looks at the advantages and disadvantages of each CSS method: external, internal and inline.

CSS method	Advantages	Disadvantages
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External	The style sheet is separated from the HTML document, providing a clear structure and allowing reuse of the style sheet across multiple documents.	Uploading multiple CSS files can increase the page loading time. The page cannot be rendered correctly until the style sheet is completely uploaded.
Internal	The style sheet is included in the same file, so it is easy to update the styles.	Because the style sheet is included in the same file, it increases the code size, resulting in longer page loading times.
Inline	This is an easy and fast method for applying styles to an HTML document. It is convenient for testing styling options.	Adding CSS rules to each element can be time-consuming and requires a lot of effort to implement, check, and update.

So, to summarise, an external style sheet is the preferred method of applying CSS because:

- it allows you to edit all linked instances of the style at once
- the CSS code is kept consistent in a single, easy-to-find location
- you can reference multiple style sheets, allowing the look and feel to be defined in a modular manner.

Let's return to the code used to create the BIT703 Web Technologies web page. We'll now create an external style sheet which has been linked to the HTML code. Notice how using an external style sheet keeps the CSS code separate from the HTML code.



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HTML

CSS

Result

EDIT ON

LIVE

```
h1 {  
  color: white;  
  text-align: left;  
  background-color: #008080;  
  font-family: Arial, Helvetica,  
  sans-serif;  
  font-size: 24px;  
  font-style: italic;  
}
```

Resources

1x 0.5x 0.25x

Rerun

Example 6.4 External style sheet



☒ Style an HTML document using CSS

Non-Assessed

Status: Done
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Reset ↺

Create a CSS style sheet to apply styling rules to an HTML document. Focus on selectors, hierarchy and pseudo-elements for specific styling effects.

1. Write the appropriate CSS rules to style the following HTML elements and their conditions:

- `p` elements: Ensure text is centred and coloured. Any shade is acceptable.
- `div p` elements: Style all `<p>` elements nested inside a `<div>` with right-aligned text and a specific colour (different from the main colour).
- `p::first-line`: Style the first line of text in any `<p>` element. Include changes such as font size, text decoration (such as underline) and a background colour.
- `div > p`: Apply specific styling to `<p>` elements directly inside a `<div>` (those that are immediate children) using alignment and colour rules.
- `a:hover`: Create a hover effect for `<a>` elements by changing their background colour to red.

2. Notes

- Exact colours are not required, but choose contrasting ones to demonstrate the effect clearly.
- Do not alter the structure of the HTML provided below.
- Ensure the CSS code is well-structured and logically organised.

3. HTML for reference

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```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=
1.0">
  <title>Styled HTML</title>
  <link rel="stylesheet" href="styles.css">
</head>
<body>
  <p>Some fantastic text, centered on the screen in a specific colour.
    <br>This is another line of text.
    <br>Used to style specific parts of an element. You can use this to style the first line of a paragraph element.
  </p>
  <div>
    <p>
      Selects elements according to a specific <a href="#">relationship</a> between them.
    </p>
  </div>
</body>
</html>
```

☒ I have completed this task



Take a look at the CodePen link to see how we applied the code: Task: Style an HTML document using CSS.

Previous attempts ▼



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The next section will dive deeper into CSS. You will explore aspects such as CSS layout, fonts and animations.



Thoughts on this page?

